

ON TECHNIQUE

The value of folk song

Bartók's fascination with folk song lay not in petty nationalism, but in his belief in its fundamental importance. In an essay titled "Folk song and Art Music" in 1921, he argued that folk song had long been part of the arsenal of the most sophisticated composers, citing examples in the music of Haydn and Beethoven and—further back—in the use of Lutheran chorales in 17th-century music. He suggested that references to folk music helped listeners relate better to new works, and that composers, such as Schoenberg, who disconnected from such roots produced music that was difficult to understand. Exploring folk music, he wrote, "is a study which will refine the budding musician's taste and considerably enlarge his horizon."



BARTOK RECORDING FOLK SONGS DURING A JOURNEY IN
TRANSYLVANIA

Béla Bartók was born on March 25, 1881, in the town of Nagyszentmiklós, Transylvania (then Hungary, now Sînnicolau Mare in Romania). His mother was a pianist, his father the headmaster of a local school. When Béla was seven, his father